

Describe an important event that you have celebrated

You should say:

- What it was
- When it was
- Where you celebrated it
- And explain how you felt about it

Well, when it comes to events or occasions that are celebrated in my country, we celebrate birthdays, graduations, weddings, wedding anniversaries, Christmas, New Year to name but a few. The one I'd like to talk about is my university graduation.

My university degree lasted four years and I was over the moon when I received the news that I had passed, as at times it was challenging and it seemed never-ending. The relief I felt was indescribable. When it came to my graduation day, I wanted to make it a day to remember. My family and siblings all attended the ceremony. It was quite nerve-wracking waiting for them to announce my name and then I had to walk on stage and collect my degree certificate. The look of pride on my family's faces is something I'll never forget.

Cue Card - Events

After the ceremony, we went to a fancy restaurant where we had a slap-up meal. I treated my parents because they had supported me through university so I wanted to pay them back for all their support and generosity. It was the least I could do.

Later that day, I met up with my fellow graduates and we had a party. We were dancing and partying until the early hours. It really was the perfect end to the perfect day. There was a hint of sadness though, because it was the end of one chapter and the start of another. My student days were over and it was time to go out into the real world and get a job. Nevertheless, it was a great way to mark the end of my student days and I'll never forget it.

Describe a time when you got up early in the morning

You should say:

- When it was
- Why you got up early
- Who you were with
- And explain how you felt about getting up early

When I was studying in high school, I used to get up early every day and now that I am working, I still have to get up early, so I am going to talk about a time when I had to get up ridiculously early.

It was about a year ago and I was going on a trip overseas and the bus departure time was 3am. This was bad enough, but I live about three quarters of an hour away from the bus departure point so this meant I had to leave the house at 2.15 and, therefore, I needed to get up at 1.30. I had a dilemma. Did I go to bed at 9pm and try to get a few hours' sleep before getting up or did I try to stay awake? I chose the former because I am not a night owl and after 10pm, I struggle to keep my eyes open. However, when I know that I have to get up early, I can't get to sleep so I was tossing and turning for hours.

Cue Card - Events

As the minutes ticked by, I was getting increasingly stressed because I was still wide awake and I knew that if I didn't get to sleep, I would feel dreadful the next day. I don't know precisely what time I nodded off, but I must have done because I was rudely awakened at 1.30 by my alarm clock. Normally, when my alarm goes off, I hit the snooze button and have an extra ten minutes in bed, but I knew if I did this, I might fall back into a deep sleep and sleep through my alarm. Moreover, because I was alone in the house at the time, I didn't have anyone to wake me if I slept in.

So, I dragged myself out of bed and jumped in the shower. Having a shower wakes me up and I feel energised after having one so despite only having a few hours' sleep, I felt alright. Mind you, after sitting on a bus for 12 hours, I was feeling pretty rough by the end of the day and fell into a deep sleep as soon as my head hit the pillow that night. I hope it is a long time before I have to get up at that ungodly hour* again.

*ungodly hour = a time of day that is too early or late

PART 3

What are the benefits of having a nap in the day?

Well, sleep experts have found that **taking a nap** can improve many things, for instance...

It can **increase alertness, boost creativity, reduce stress, improve stamina, motor skills and accuracy, aid in weight loss, reduce the risk of heart attack, brighten your mood and boost memory...**

On top of all that, if you are living in a hot country, **having a siesta** in the middle of the day is recommended because it is the hottest part of the day and it is virtually impossible to work in such extreme heat.



to have a cat nap = to have a short sleep

PART 3

What do you think are the benefits of getting up early?

Well, there is a proverb: **the early bird catches the worm.**

This means that the earlier you do something the more likely you are to be successful.

In terms of **productivity**, it is believed that the earlier you do something in the day, you are going to be more **productive**.



PART 2

Describe a time when you saw a child/children behave badly in public

You should say:

- Where it was
- What the child (children) was doing
- How others reacted to it
- And explain how you felt about it

Cue Card - Events

I have to say that it didn't take me long to **come up with** an answer to this question because this happened very recently so **it's still fresh in my mind***. The **incident** happened a couple of weeks ago.

***to be fresh in your mind =** you can still remember it clearly

I was shopping in my local supermarket and **it was teeming with** people. It was **a boiling hot day** and although the **air con** was on, **everyone was feeling** a bit **fractious****. Because it was so busy, the **queues** for the **tills** were **incredibly** long. **They were snaked around** the store. Just in front of me in the queue was a **youngish** mum with her **toddler**. I have to say the little boy **had been well behaved** up until that point but **we were queuing** for **a good half hour** and he just got **fed up**.

****fractious =** getting angry at small things



Cue Card - Events

He started having a tantrum and threw himself on the floor and was screaming at the top of his voice. It was a major meltdown*. The mum started trying to distract him by giving him her phone but he threw that on the floor. She was really struggling and didn't know what to do. Everyone was looking at her and I could hear some people tutting and looking down on her. The poor woman was trying her best. I said to her that I would hold her place in the queue if she wanted to step outside for a few minutes. She was on the verge of tears** and thanked me.

*to have a meltdown = to get very angry

**to be on the verge/brink of something = to be very close to doing something

About five minutes later, she came back and her child was eating a bread roll and was much calmer. She thanked me profusely*** and luckily the queue started moving faster. I felt very sorry for her. It's not easy shopping with a little one at the best of times**** and the heat didn't help.

***to thank someone profusely = to thank someone over and over again

****at the best of times = when everything is going well



Fluency and Coherence - Organisation

Grammatical Range and Accuracy - Grammar

Lexical Resource - Vocabulary

Describe your idea of the perfect holiday

You should say:

- Where you would go
- Who you would go with
- What you would do there
- And explain why you think this would be the perfect holiday

Well, I'm not really a sun worshipper because in the sun I tend to get all hot and bothered, but if I had the chance to go on my perfect holiday, I would go to the Gold Coast in Australia. Generally, I try to avoid tourist traps and prefer to holiday in less commercialised places; however, the Gold Coast is on my bucket list.

Obviously, I'd like to go there with my family and because we all lead such hectic lives, it'd be great to spend some quality time together. My kids are into water sports and, in this particular part of the world, there are ample opportunities to do activities such as SCUBA diving and surfing.

In addition to spending time at the beach and trying to avoid getting sunstroke, I'd like to check out all the cafes and places to eat in the area. I've heard that this area is a foodie's paradise and as I am obsessed with food, I'd be able to enjoy all the different kinds of food on offer. I'm not really into fine dining so I'd look for independent cafes and street food, rather than flashy restaurants or chains like Starbucks.

Cue Card - Events

I **guess this would be** my perfect holiday because **it would be the** **holiday of a lifetime** and it is **literally** on the other side of the world so it's not somewhere I can **pop to** whenever I feel like it.

Here are some useful words and phrases, which are all connected to holidays.

a sun worshipper	in the sun I get all hot and bothered	to sunbathe	to get a suntan
to get sunstroke	to get sunburnt	to stay in the shade	sunblock
package holiday	a tourist trap	hordes of tourists	self-catering

Describe a happy experience you have had

You should say:

- Where you were
- When it happened
- Who you were with
- And explain why you felt happy

When I read this topic, the first thing that came to mind was a party that was organised for my 16th birthday by my parents. It was a surprise party so I didn't know anything about it. To be honest, I actually thought that my friends had forgotten my birthday because no one was talking about it or asking me what I wanted to do.

When I brought it up, everyone dismissed it by saying 'sorry, I'm a bit busy at the moment so can we do something next month to celebrate it?' This made me incredibly depressed that no one could be bothered to spend time with me on my special day. My parents were aware of my distress and suggested that we go out for a slap-up meal instead. What I didn't know was that they were secretly planning this surprise party for me.

Cue Card - Events

On the day of my birthday, I got a few text messages from **close friends** wishing me a happy birthday. **Even though** the day was good because I went out shopping with my parents and **siblings** and I got a **brand-new** iPad, I **felt a bit down** because I thought that my friends **were ignoring** me. At 5pm, we went to the restaurant and as I walked through the doors, I heard 'surprise' and was **gobsmacked** to see all of my friends and family there.

I was **astounded** that my friends and parents **had managed** to organise this event and **no one had breathed a word to me**. I was **thrilled to bits** that all the people who are special to me were in that room. The food was **delicious** and then there was a disco so we danced **until the early hours**. I'm not sure any birthday can **top** that one and I'll **certainly** never forget it.

Cue Card - Events

Describe a time when you got bored when you were with others

You should say:

- When it was
- Who you were with
- What you did
- And explain why you were bored

I was struggling to think of a time when this happened because I don't often get bored when I'm with others, but I do tend to get bored when I'm on my own. Then I suddenly remembered an occasion, a few years back, so I've decided to talk about that time.

I can't remember precisely when it was, but like I said, it was several years ago and I went with a group of close friends to the pictures/cinema to see La La Land. This film won loads of awards and everyone was raving about it* so I was really looking forward to it. I'm a massive fan of musicals so I couldn't wait.

So the film started and during the opening number, I was already thinking 'this isn't what I was expecting'. The male and female leads are top actors, but they're not great singers. Don't get me wrong they're not terrible, but in a musical I expect pitch-perfect voices.

To rave about something = to talk enthusiastically about something
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Cue Card - Events

Whenever I watch any film, if I am not gripped by it in the first few minutes, I switch off and, to be brutally honest, I found this film mind-numbingly boring and I was bored to death. It was tedious, monotonous and I actually nodded off.

My friends/mates were shocked at the end when I confessed that I had fallen asleep because they all thoroughly enjoyed it. I find that when a film is hyped so much, my expectations are very high and when it doesn't meet them, I'm often bored stiff. I just found the acting and the singing mediocre and it didn't grab my attention.

I know I'm hard to please, but I loved Frozen and stayed awake for the whole film and it's a kids film really. I think the problem is, I have the attention span* of a goldfish and get bored too quickly.

***attention span** = the length of time for which a person is able to concentrate on a particular activity or subject

PART 3

Why are people less interested in reading books nowadays?

I'm not sure that it is the case that people are less interested, I strongly believe that this is a time issue.

On the whole, we are working longer hours, we are more stressed, and we have very little downtime compared to our ancestors.

The 9 to 5 job is a thing of the past so I think the fact that we all have less time, we are shattered/exhausted and fall asleep as soon as our heads hit the pillow* is the major factor in the decline in reading.



*to fall asleep as soon as your head hits the pillow = to fall asleep very quickly

PART 2

Describe an art exhibition you have visited

You should say:

- Where it was
- When it was
- What was on display
- And explain how you felt about it

Cue Card - Events

I apologise in advance for my answer because I'm just not into art so visiting art exhibitions is not something I do or have done on a regular basis. The only thing I can think of that I can talk about is an art exhibition that was held in my university/school a few years back. I visited it with a few mates, but to be perfectly honest, we were just killing time* because art's just not my thing**.

*to kill time = to spend time doing something while you are waiting for something else

**to not be your thing = to be not interested in it

I can't remember precisely when it was because I don't have a head for dates*, it was when I was studying in university and the event was being held in the library. One day, we were preparing a presentation in there and we got finished earlier than expected and had half an hour to kill before our next lecture. We decided to have a quick look around the exhibition. I don't really know technical terms** for art, but I think it was abstract art***.



*to have a head for something = to be able to do something well

**technical terms = a word that has a specific meaning within a specific field of expertise.

***abstract art = does not attempt to represent an accurate depiction of a visual reality but instead use shapes, colours, forms and gestural marks to achieve its effect

Fluency and Coherence - Organisation
Grammatical Range and Accuracy - Grammar
Lexical Resource - Vocabulary

Cue Card - Events

Don't get me wrong*, I'm not **dissing it**** and it looked incredibly professional. I certainly couldn't produce anything like that, but **it's just not for me**. I'm more into photography rather than art so my home **is filled with***** photos, for example, **landscape and portrait photography**. I have **loads of** photos on my walls. They are my memories so are more **meaningful****** for me.

***Don't get me wrong** = don't misunderstand me

****to diss** = to disrespect

*****to be filled with** = to be full of

******meaningful** = important



Like I said, it isn't my thing at all; **however**, I was impressed by it and I **wish I could produce** something similar. I **can't draw to save my life*** and I didn't study art at school so that is one of the reasons **I've never got into it****. Maybe, in the future, **the distant future** though, I will **appreciate***** it more. I think I should start by going to photography exhibitions because I think I would enjoy them more.

***I can't draw to save my life** = If you say that you can't do something to save your life, you mean that you absolutely cannot do that thing

****to get into something** = to become interested in something

*****to appreciate something** = to respect; to value something

Fluency and Coherence - Organisation

Grammatical Range and Accuracy - Grammar

Lexical Resource - Vocabulary

Describe an important journey that was delayed

You should say:

- Why it was important
- Why it was delayed
- What happened
- And explain how you felt about it

It was quite tricky to decide what to talk about because I often get delayed when travelling for a variety of reasons such as traffic congestion, but they're not particularly important trips so I was struggling to think of something but then I suddenly remembered a nightmare journey to London, so I've decided to talk about that experience.

I can't remember precisely when it was, because I have a terrible memory for dates but it was several years back and I was taking the train from Manchester to London to visit my friend, who was studying there at the time. We had planned to go to the theatre that night and I couldn't wait. The train was packed* and all the seats were taken so I was sitting next to someone but for the first half of the journey we didn't interact because we were both watching something on our phones. Suddenly, the train ground to a halt**. It was mildly annoying because I had no phone signal at that point.

*to be packed = filled to capacity; full

**to grind to a halt = to stop or no longer work well

Cue Card - Events

Anyway, because we couldn't continue watching what we were watching, the girl sitting next to me asked me if I knew what was happening. I said no, I had no idea, so we killed time with idle chat*. After a few minutes there was an announcement over the speaker and the conductor said there was a technical issue with the train so we needed to disembark**. Like I said, the train was jam-packed so it took ages to get off the train. We were close to a station so we had to walk along the tracks and wait at the station.

*idle chat = meaningless talking that fills the silence while waiting

**to disembark = to get off

After what seemed like an age, another train turned up and we got on that, but it was smaller than the original train so it was standing room only***. My friend was waiting at the station and we just made it to the theatre on time, but I was famished because I hadn't eaten so I had to have popcorn to keep me going. The show was amazing, but being late and stressed did spoil the evening somewhat.

***standing room only = all the seats are/were filled

Describe a time you saw an interesting animal

You should say:

- What it was
- When you saw it
- Where you saw it
- And explain why you thought it was interesting

It was quite tricky to decide which animal to talk about because I am an animal lover and find all animals interesting but then I suddenly remembered my first experience with a wild animal so I've decided to talk about that particular animal.

I can't remember precisely when it was because I have a terrible memory for dates, but it was several years back when I was travelling around the UK/Japan/China/India with my family and we went to a zoo. I've always been really keen on polar bears. I've loved them for as long as I can remember though I can't fully explain why. I suppose it has something to do with the fact that they seem so cute and cuddly, mind you, if you tried to cuddle one you would probably get your head bitten off.

I've never actually seen a polar bear in the wild and although it was fascinating to see a polar bear in the flesh, I also found it quite disturbing to see such a handsome animal in a cage. It was walking from side to side of the cage, prowling around and obviously not happy to be out of its natural habitat.

Cue Card - Events

One thing I admire about these creatures is their ability to be so solitary and self-dependent. They often go for months without meeting other bears and, apart from during the mating season, they seem to prefer to be alone rather than in a pack.

Of course the really sad thing about polar bears is that they will probably be extinct within half a century. They depend on ice and, as ice forms later in the year now, because of global warming, the bears are getting hungrier and, consequently, more of them are not able to make it through the long winter. It would be such a shame if polar bears died out completely. They are one of the most stunningly beautiful animals in the world and we should do everything we can to preserve them. I guess some zoos have breeding programmes* and that is a good thing because if they die out then they will be gone forever.

*breeding programmes =

the planned breeding of a group of animals or plants, usually involving at least several individuals and extending over several generations

Describe a time you were a member of a team

You should say:

- What it was
- What you did
- Why you did it
- And explain how you felt about it

It was quite tricky to decide what to talk about because it's not something I do that much nowadays but then I suddenly remembered working on a team project in high school so I've decided to talk about that particular time.

I can't remember precisely when it was because I have a terrible memory for dates, but it was many years back, like I said, when I was studying in secondary school. Personally, given the choice, I prefer to work by myself. I'm not a loner, by any means, but I just find working alone a lot easier and less stressful because you don't have to worry about group dynamics. Having said that though, on this particular occasion, it all went without a hitch* and I did enjoy it. I think what made it successful was that we appointed a group leader and she led the group well. Surprisingly, there was no competition between members and the group was cohesive**.

*to go without a hitch =

To happen without difficulties or problems

**cohesive =

To be united and work together effectively

Cue Card - Events

The project that **we were given** was to create a five minute video about climate change. There were five of us in the team and we **allocated** different roles to different members such as **research, script writing, presentation, editing** etc. **I was delegated** the research role and **it suited me** because I prefer to be **behind the camera**.

We were given a four-week **time limit** to **carry out the project** and what worked really well for us was that we spent the first week planning it **thoroughly and carefully/meticulously**. **Assignments** such as this often **fail** or are **stressful/traumatic** because people **rush into** the recording stage. For any team project, **good teamwork skills** are essential. There is a saying '**there is no I in team***' and it is **vital** to remember this. **Having a good rapport with** your team-mates helps and I think this was **key** to our successful teamwork **on this occasion**.

***there is no I in team =**

This set phrase is often used to remind team members that they have to work together, and not be selfish. When you spell the word "team", you don't use the letter 'i' so this phrase means: The team as a whole is important, not the individual members.

Cue Card - Events

Describe a time when the weather prevented an activity

You should say:

- What it was
- Why it prevented the activity
- What you did
- And explain how you felt about it

It was quite tricky to decide what to talk about because I was struggling to remember the last time I was forced to change my plans because of the weather. Usually, regardless of the weather conditions, I just carry on with what I'm doing or what I've planned, but then I suddenly remembered a time a few years ago that I've decided to talk about.

I can't remember precisely when it was because I have a terrible memory for dates, but it was several years back when I was travelling around the UK/Japan/China/India with a few of my close friends. That particular day, we had planned to go to the beach and we had checked the weather forecast in advance, but weather, unfortunately, can be unpredictable and when we got up *it was chucking it down. To say we were disappointed is an understatement. We had been travelling for days and we were absolutely shattered and desperately needed to chill out for a couple of days.

It was raining cats and dogs = it was raining very heavily

*it was chucking it down = it was raining very heavily

** an understatement = used when a speaker wants to make a situation seem less strong or important than it is

Cue Card - Events

Over breakfast, we realised we needed a **plan B**. None of us wanted to go sightseeing, **partly** because of the **torrential rain**, but also because **we were dead on our feet** and needed **to recharge our batteries**. My friend went on TripAdvisor and started looking through the most popular activities in the area.

One of the most popular activities was an indoor swimming pool so we decided **to give it a try** because it was only a short bus ride away from our hotel. When we got there, we were **delighted** to discover that it was **a tropical paradise**. **It would have been** great to go to **a golden sandy beach with crystal blue sea**, but on a rainy day this was the next best thing.

*to recharge my/your/our batteries = to regain strength and energy by resting for a period of time

Cue Card - Events

Describe an interesting conversation you had with someone

You should say:

- Who it was with
- When it was
- What it was about
- And explain why you found it interesting

I was struggling to think of a situation to talk about because every conversation I thought of would probably sound boring to another person, but I've decided to talk about a chat I had with a friend of mine who went to the UK to study and he told me about some of things that he experienced when he was there. I can't remember exactly when we had this conversation, but it was when he came back for a holiday after his first year of study. We met up for a bite to eat and a catch up. We've been friends since primary school and it was great to see him and hang out.

The UK is on my bucket list of places to visit so I was eager to know what it is like. The first thing he said was that the British are so polite. If they bump into you, they apologise, but also if you bump into them, they apologise as well. If they walk into a door, they'll say sorry to the door. People in my country are nowhere near as polite as this.

Cue Card - Events

Another thing he mentioned was that they are obsessed with tea. If you are feeling down, they'll offer you a cup of tea. If you are celebrating something, they'll offer you a cup of tea. As soon as he walked into a British person's house, the first thing they said was 'I'll put the kettle on'. It is considered rude to refuse. Tea drinking is such a big part of their culture.

The reason why I found this conversation fascinating is because I love finding out about other nationalities and the things that they do that are different. There were loads of other things that he told me about living in the UK and as a result of our chat, I'm keener than ever to go. Hopefully, in the near future, I'll get the chance.

PART 3

What are the differences between men and women's conversations?

Some might say that males talk about sport and females about food and fashion.

Personally, I know many men who **chat about** food and the latest fashions and, **likewise**, many **women who are into** football.

It is often said that women gossip and men don't. However, this is not the case so...

Personally, I feel that it's wrong to stereotype*.



*To have a widely held but fixed and oversimplified image or idea of a particular type of person or thing
e.g. In many societies there is the stereotype of the woman as the carer and the man as the breadwinner.

Describe an occasion when somebody gave you positive suggestions

You should say:

- What the suggestions were
- Who made the suggestions
- What you did
- And explain why the suggestions were positive and how you felt

Throughout our lives, we are faced with negativity and criticism. Most of the time, these negative voices come from within and we put ourselves down a lot. Throughout my time in high school, my grades were not great and I was convinced that I would leave school at the age of 16 and get a job because I was not academic enough to go onto higher education.

Things changed, however, when a new English teacher started at my school. This woman did not know me and had no pre-conceived ideas about my ability or lack of it. In the first class, she asked us to write an autobiographical account of our lives. As I was writing this piece, I found I was thoroughly enjoying recounting stories from my childhood. After submitting it, I forgot all about it. Three weeks later, the teacher gave us our essays back and I was stunned to see that I had got an A. I had never received an A grade in my life.

Cue Card - Events

In addition to the grade, **this teacher had written** that she found my writing **incredibly moving** and my use of language was **extremely sophisticated** for my age. She suggested that I include some more **anecdotes** from my childhood.

Up until this point, I'd never been a big fan of writing, but because of this **positive feedback**, I felt inspired to write. **Finally**, someone **believed in me** and it motivated me to write more. When I gave the teacher my essay again, she gave me some suggestions of how to improve it even more and once again, **I was keen to follow her advice**.

The power of positivity is incredible. **Many think** that if you **criticise**, it makes people more **determined** to prove **the critics** wrong, but I strongly believe that this is not the case. Positive suggestions and feedback, **certainly in my case**, **encouraged me** to improve. Now **I am thinking about** going to study **creative writing** at university!

Describe a situation where you were not allowed to use your mobile phone

You should say:

- Where it was
- When it was
- Why it wasn't allowed
- And explain how you felt about it

It was quite tricky to decide what to talk about because there are not many situations when I can't use my phone apart from in the cinema and nothing immediately came to mind then I suddenly remembered going on a training course when this happened so I've decided to talk about that particular time.

I can't remember precisely when it was because I have a terrible memory for dates, but it was a few years back when I was doing a training course for work. Generally, at work I always have my phone on my desk and although I try not to look at it much, I have to confess* that I check it far too often. I guess everyone is pretty much the same and we are constantly checking our phone and it has become a bad habit. Anyway, when the course started, the first thing the trainer said was 'switch off your phones and put them away'. There was an audible gasp** in the room and everyone looked irritated.

*to confess = to admit

**an audible gasp = a gasp is a short quick breath of air that you take in through your mouth, especially when you are surprised, shocked, or in pain. Audible means it can be heard.

Cue Card - Events

The **instructor** explained that **on average** 56 minutes a day **are spent** checking your phone at work so if **you are working** an 8 hour day with an hour for lunch, nearly 14% of your **productivity* is lost** through phone **distraction**. When he said this, there was another **gasp** and people were shocked that so much time **is wasted**. He called it 'attention pollution' and said that smartphones **have become** the cigarettes of the 21st century as they are equally **addictive****, **albeit***** not **harmful** in the same way. When he explained it in this way, it really made me think about how **distracting** phones are.

Despite this, **I have to say** that I found it **incredibly frustrating** to be without my phone all day. **It did make me** more **aware** of how often I check it and **I like to believe** that I have **cut down** and **am doing** it less frequently. I don't think I can **give it up** completely, but **I am definitely trying** to **keep my checking to a minimum******.

***productivity** = the output of an employee over a specific period of time

****addictive** = you cannot stop using it or doing it

*****albeit (formal)** = although

******to keep something to a minimum** = to do something as little as possible

Cue Card - Events

Describe a time when you met someone for the first time

You should say:

- Who it was
- When it was
- Where it was
- And explain how you felt about it

It was quite tricky to decide who to talk about because I can't remember the last time I met someone for the first time because I've known all my mates for ages so I was struggling to think of someone but then I suddenly remembered chatting to someone on a train who has since become a friend, well on social media, so I've decided to talk about that experience.

I can't remember precisely when it was, because I have a terrible memory for dates but it was several years back and I was taking the train from Manchester to London to visit my friend, who was studying there at the time. The train was packed* and all the seats were taken so I was sitting next to someone but for the first half of the journey we didn't interact because we were both watching something on our phones. Suddenly, the train ground to a halt**. It was mildly annoying because I had no phone signal at that point.

*to be packed = filled to capacity; full

**to grind to a halt = to stop or no longer work well

Cue Card - Events

Anyway, because we couldn't continue watching what we were watching, the girl sitting next to me asked me if I knew what was happening. I said no, I had no idea, and I can't recall what we said next but we started chatting. It turned out that she was studying at the same uni as my friend and was returning after a long weekend in Manchester. It was idle chat* at first, but the more we talked, we discovered that we had a lot in common** such as musical tastes. We didn't even realise the train started moving again 40 minutes later.

*idle chat = meaningless talking that fills the silence while waiting

**to have a lot in common with = to share interests, beliefs, attitudes, opinions, etc

As we approached London, she asked me if I was on Facebook and I am so we followed each other and, like I said, we are into the same bands so we share stuff about them on there. Although I wouldn't call her a close friend, she's an internet friend, she certainly made that journey much more interesting and she was a great person to kill time** with.

**to kill time = to do something that keeps you busy while you are waiting for something else to happen